

Saint-Denis and Chartres

The Gothic style in Europe originated in a new choir at the abbey of Saint-Denis near Paris, in 1140. Built under the direction of Abbot Suger (1081–1151), it revolutionized architecture. The unknown architect remodelled the church (opposite) with pointed arches, huge stained-glass windows, high stone vaults and flying buttresses. Previously, such lavishness was considered too garish and showy for a Christian building, but in his interpretation of the Bible, Suger saw his church as an image of God's kingdom. He ordered it to be flooded with coloured light, achieving an unprecedented brightness. Arches also pointed up to Heaven and allowed new types of vaulting.

This blend of spiritual vision and engineering skill spread to other churches. The first Gothic cathedral, Chartres (1194–1220), was built of limestone with a green copper roof. Dominated by flying buttresses and two contrasting spires, the cruciform plan features a spacious nave and façades bearing hundreds of sculpted figures depicting biblical themes.

